

Day 107 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Current Affairs in TN History/Culture/Heritage (9): Smithsonian's Return of 3 Chola/Vijayanagar Bronzes

READING MATERIAL

Covers the Smithsonian's January 2026 repatriation of 3 ancient South Indian bronze sculptures, originally from Tamil Nadu temples, back to India.

Q: When did the Smithsonian's National Museum of Asian Art announce the return of 3 bronze sculptures to India?

A: 28 January 2026.

Q: Name the 3 sculptures, their periods, and original Tamil Nadu temple locations.

A: 1. Shiva Nataraja (c. 990 AD, Chola period) — from Shir Bhava Aushadesvara Temple, Tirutturaippundi. 2. Somaskanda (12th century, Chola period) — from Visvanatha Temple, Alattur village, Mannarkudi taluk. 3. Saint Sundarar with Paravai (16th century, Vijayanagar period) — from a Shiva Temple, Veerasolapuram village, Kallakurichi taluk.

Q: How was the provenance of these sculptures confirmed?

A: Through temple photographs taken between 1956-1959 (Nataraja: 1957; Somaskanda: 1959; Saint Sundarar: 1956), researched in collaboration with the Photo Archives of the French Institute of Pondicherry.

Q: How did these sculptures originally enter the Smithsonian's collection?

A: The Nataraja entered in 2002 via the Doris Wiener Gallery using FORGED provenance documents. The Somaskanda and Saint Sundarar arrived in 1987 as part of a 1,000-object donation by Arthur M. Sackler, with unclear acquisition histories.

Q: What are the terms of the Nataraja's return specifically?

A: Ownership formally reverts to India, but the Nataraja will remain on LONG-TERM LOAN to the Smithsonian under a shared-stewardship arrangement — displayed alongside information about its origins, removal, and repatriation.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. The Smithsonian announced the return of 3 South Indian bronze sculptures to India on:

- A. 28 December 2025
- B. 28 January 2026 ✓**
- C. 28 February 2026
- D. 28 March 2026

Explanation: 28 January 2026. [medium, web-research]

2. The Shiva Nataraja bronze being returned dates to approximately which period?

- A. Pallava period, 7th century
- B. Chola period, c. 990 AD ✓**
- C. Vijayanagar period, 16th century
- D. Pandya period, 13th century

Explanation: Chola period, c. 990 AD. [medium, web-research]

3. How was the provenance of these bronzes confirmed as originating from Tamil Nadu temples?

- A. DNA testing of the metal
- B. Temple photographs from 1956-1959 ✓**
- C. Sanskrit inscriptions on the statues
- D. Carbon dating only

Explanation: Temple photographs from 1956-1959. [medium, web-research]

4. How did the Shiva Nataraja bronze enter the Smithsonian's collection in 2002?

- A. Direct purchase from the Government of India
- B. Via the Doris Wiener Gallery using forged provenance documents ✓**
- C. As a diplomatic gift

D. Through a public auction

Explanation: Via the Doris Wiener Gallery, using forged provenance documents. [hard, web-research]

5. Under the return terms, the Nataraja bronze will:

A. Be destroyed

B. Remain on long-term loan to the Smithsonian under shared stewardship, with ownership reverted to India ✓

C. Be sold to a private collector

D. Never be displayed again

Explanation: Remain on long-term loan with ownership reverted to India. [medium, web-research]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Logical Reasoning

READING MATERIAL

Logical Reasoning is 1 of 6 named Reasoning skills (Part B Unit II, 10 questions total for the whole unit). Real exam evidence shows TNPSC's 'logical reasoning' label covers a wide variety of puzzle types, not just classic syllogisms — expect position-counting, ranking-from-clues, and direction-sense questions under this same heading too.

Q: Method — syllogism (statements → which conclusions necessarily follow): Statements: 'Some pens are books. All books are rods.' Conclusions: I. All pens are rods. II. Some pens are rods. III. Some books are pens. IV. All rods are pens. Which conclusions follow?

A: Only II and III follow. 'Some pens are books' + 'All books are rods' guarantees that AT LEAST SOME pens are rods (II) and that some books are indeed pens (III, since 'some pens are books' can be reversed to 'some books are pens'). It does NOT guarantee ALL pens are rods (I — only the 'some' pens that are books are guaranteed to be rods) or that ALL rods are pens (IV — nothing says rods can't include non-pen things).

Q: Method — position-in-a-line counting: Richard is 15th from the front in a column of boys. There are three times as many boys behind him as in front. How many boys are between Richard and the 7th boy from the end?

A: In front of Richard: 14 boys. Behind him: $3 \times 14 = 42$ boys. Total boys = $14 + 1 + 42 = 57$. The 7th from the end is at position $57 - 7 + 1 = 51$ from the front. Richard is at position 15. Boys between them = $51 - 15 - 1 = 35$.

Q: Method — algebraic word problem framed as a 'logical' puzzle: 106 trees were planted; non-fruit-bearing trees were 2 more than thrice the fruit-bearing trees. How many fruit-bearing trees were planted?

A: Let fruit-bearing = x . Non-fruit-bearing = $3x + 2$. Total: $x + 3x + 2 = 106 \rightarrow 4x = 104 \rightarrow x = 26$.

Q: Method — ranking from multiple comparative clues: Given several statements comparing four people's scores (e.g., 'Rama scored more than Rani but less than Rathna...'), determine who scored highest.

A: Work through each comparative clue methodically, building a single ordered chain (e.g., Rathna > Rama > Ramya > Rani), rather than trying to hold all comparisons in your head at once — write the partial order down step by step as each clue is read.

Q: Method — meaningful word sequencing: Arrange in a logical sequence: Honey, Flower, Bee, Wax.

A: Flower → Bee → Honey → Wax. The logic: a bee visits a Flower, produces Honey, and the Honey-making process also yields Wax (beeswax) — order reflects the natural/causal sequence of the process, not alphabetical or arbitrary order.

Q: Method — direction sense: A person starts walking, turns left, then turns left again, and is now heading East. Which direction did they originally start in?

A: West. Two consecutive left turns reverse the original direction (left+left = 180° turn), so if they end up heading East, they must have started heading West.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Statements: 'Some doctors are teachers. All teachers are readers.' Conclusions: I. Some doctors are readers. II. All doctors are readers. III. Some readers are teachers. Which follow?

A. Only I and III ✓

B. Only II

C. All three

D. None

Explanation: I and III follow the same logic as the worked example (some doctors are guaranteed readers via the teacher link; some readers are guaranteed teachers by reversing 'some'). II overreaches — not ALL doctors are teachers, so not all are guaranteed readers. [hard, authored]

2. In a column of boys, Meena is 10th from the front, and there are twice as many boys behind her as in front. How many boys are in the column in total?

A. 27

B. 28 ✓

C. 29

D. 30

Explanation: In front: 9. Behind: $2 \times 9 = 18$. Total = $9 + 1 + 18 = 28$. [medium, authored]

3. A farmer planted 84 saplings in total. The number of flowering saplings was 3 more than twice the number of non-flowering saplings. How many non-flowering saplings were planted?

A. 25

B. 27 ✓

C. 29

D. 31

Explanation: Let non-flowering=x. Flowering=2x+3. Total: $x+2x+3=84 \rightarrow 3x=81 \rightarrow x=27$. [medium, authored]

4. Arrange in a logical sequence: Seed, Tree, Fruit, Sapling.

A. Seed-Sapling-Tree-Fruit ✓

B. Seed-Tree-Sapling-Fruit

C. Sapling-Seed-Tree-Fruit

D. Seed-Fruit-Sapling-Tree

Explanation: A Seed grows into a Sapling, which matures into a Tree, which eventually bears Fruit. [easy, authored]

5. A person walks north, turns right, walks on, then turns right again. Which direction are they now facing?

A. North

B. South ✓

C. East

D. West

Explanation: Two consecutive right turns reverse the original direction: North $\rightarrow$ (right) East $\rightarrow$ (right) South. [medium, authored]

Part C – General English: Poem: "Memories of My Dad" — Rebecca D. Cook

READING MATERIAL

A daughter's loving tribute to her father, recalling small everyday acts of paternal affection. Real coaching-site evidence tests theme, specific-line meaning, and one key figure-of-speech distinction (metaphor vs. simile).

Q: Who wrote "Memories of My Dad", and what is its central subject?

A: Rebecca D. Cook. Central subject: paternal affection and respect — a daughter's loving memories of her father's everyday acts of care.

Q: What does "He wasn't a hero known by the world" suggest?

A: He held heroic status only for his child — he wasn't famous or publicly celebrated, but was a hero specifically within his own family's eyes.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "My daddy was God."

A: Metaphor — a direct comparison WITHOUT using 'like' or 'as' (which would make it a simile instead). Calling him 'God' outright, rather than 'like God', is the key distinguishing feature.

Q: What does "Better than Santa" convey?

A: Happiness through genuine, heartfelt gestures — not about giving more expensive material gifts, but about the sincerity and warmth behind her father's care, which meant more than any Santa-style material giving.

Q: What does "I knew his voice before I could speak" communicate?

A: A strong emotional bond established in infancy — the connection with her father existed even before she had language, showing how foundational and early that bond was.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. "Memories of My Dad" was written by:

- A. Emily Dickinson
- B. Maya Angelou
- C. Rebecca D. Cook ✓**
- D. Sarojini Naidu

Explanation: Rebecca D. Cook. [easy, web-research]

2. The poem's primary subject matter is:

- A. Natural imagery and seasonal change
- B. Youthful pastimes
- C. Paternal affection and respect ✓**
- D. Disagreement and resolution

Explanation: Paternal affection and respect. [easy, web-research]

3. "He wasn't a hero known by the world" suggests that the father:

- A. Lacked any admirable qualities
- B. Achieved nothing significant in life
- C. Held heroic status only for his child ✓**
- D. Actively rejected public recognition

Explanation: He was a hero specifically to his child, not publicly famous. [medium, web-research]

4. "My daddy was God" is an example of which figure of speech (as opposed to a simile)?

- A. Comparison using 'like' or 'as'
- B. Direct comparison without those words ✓**
- C. Giving human qualities to non-human things
- D. Repeated consonant sounds

Explanation: Metaphor — a direct comparison without 'like/as'. [medium, web-research]

5. The reference to being "Better than Santa" conveys:

- A. Superior material gifts

B. Supernatural present-giving ability

C. Happiness through genuine, heartfelt gestures ✓

D. A description of his clothing

Explanation: Happiness through genuine, heartfelt gestures, not material wealth. [medium, web-research]

6. "I knew his voice before I could speak" communicates:

A. A purely mental/intellectual connection

B. A strong emotional bond established in infancy ✓

C. His unusually loud voice

D. Her reluctance to communicate verbally

Explanation: A strong emotional bond formed from infancy. [medium, web-research]